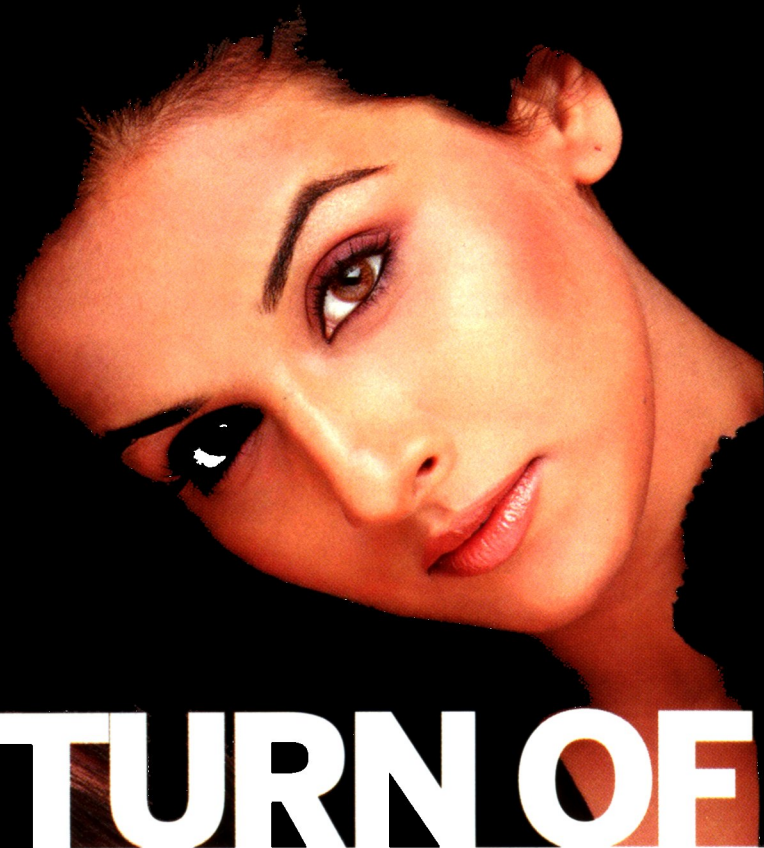


VIDYA BALAN



RETURN OF the Native

By Kaveree Bamzai

The actor returns to her classic roots, playing an earthy everywoman in a sea of pneumatic bodies with pretty faces

How does one go from overnight sensation to national joke back to ethnic sex bomb? Ask Vidya Balan. Five years in the profession, the 31-year-old has been there, scene that. From being the Next Big Thing in her first Hindi film, *Parineeta*, she became the trying-too-hard-to-be-cool babe of *Kismat Konnection*. Now, with the commercial and critical ap-

preciation for *Paa* and *Ishqiya*, Balan is back in the game, having played a mother to a 12-year-old with progeria as well as a twisted small town woman who plays two men against each other. Along the way, she's done what few women in Hindi films can, ravished Abhishek Bachchan in a train washroom and kissed Arshad Warsi senseless after sucking seductively on his injured thumb.

In an industry where beauty means hooker chic and romance translates into coy glances, Balan's sensuality is real. And in a universe where girls proliferate, she is all woman. In her own head, Balan is finally reconciled to her strengths, which is to exude what R. Balki, her director in *Paa* and her elder sister Priya's boss at Lowe Lintas, call a "hip traditionality". "She symbolises ev-